

Is More BETTER?

An acid test awaits the HRD Ministry as its plans of setting up six new IIMs run into scepticism over the issues of brand dilution and shortage of faculty

| By Rohit Pithauria |

Henry David Thoreau once said, "If a man does not keep pace with his companions, perhaps it is because he hears a different drummer." By setting up new Indian Institutes of Management (IIMs), is the Human Resource Development (HRD) Ministry not listening to the existing IIMs and beating its own drum?

The HRD Ministry has chalked out plans to set up six new IIMs by 2012. It is envisaged that four IIMs at Rohtak, Raipur, Ranchi and Tiruchirapalli will start functioning from 2010-11 and the remaining two in Uttarakhand and Rajasthan will start functioning from 2011-12. This takes the tally to a total of 13 including the functioning IIMs in Ahmedabad, Bangalore, Calcutta, Lucknow, Kozhikode, Indore and Shillong.

A sum of Rs 113.6 crore has been allocated to the plan, of which there is a provision of Rs 20 crore for the current financial year. The ministry has advertised for the post of directors for the four new IIMs and it is expected that they will be in place by November-end. For regulatory or administrative needs, the IIMs will be registered as a society in the respective states. Once that is done, the ministry will set up the Board of Governors which will exercise super-

vision over all the matters concerning the institutions—be it academic, financial or administrative.

Meanwhile, the ministry has asked the old IIMs to mentor the new ones. IIM-Rohtak will be mentored by IIM-Lucknow, IIM-Raipur by IIM-Indore, IIM-Ranchi by IIM-Calcutta and IIM-Tiruchirapalli by IIM-Bangalore. Mentoring would mean sharing course curriculum, institutional processes, cases and other teaching material.

The HRD Ministry must have imagined a grand welcome to the move, but it has been received with a little trepidation within the corridors of existing IIMs on the grounds of brand dilution, autonomy, pay structure, accountability and the faculty crunch.

Of about 2,40,000 candidates who appear in the Common Admission Test, only about 1,800 (less than 1 per cent) make it to the IIMs. "It is a very small percentage of the demand for quality management being served by the IIMs and there is definitely a need to expand," clarifies the ministry.

To maintain quality standards, some moot the idea of setting up campuses at new locations by the existing institutes. "It would have been better if the Government had permitted that. It would have meant greater synergies between the old and the new institutions and more autonomy," says S.K. Barua, director, IIM-Ahmedabad. But the HRD Ministry

states that it is better for the real expansion that new institutes are established, as, according to them, it would channel independent entry of human resources and the flow of funds in a simpler way.

All is not well on their turf either as the issues of pay structure and greater autonomy are brewing, with IIT and IIM professors voicing dissi-

